Recruiting Note

Copy the version you want into an email or message

Both versions deliberately avoid describing the argument. A respondent who knows what the table is supposed to show is no longer independent.

Short version

I have been working on something that argues AA's Traditions do a particular structural job, and the whole argument rests on a table I filled in myself. I cannot test it by thinking harder about it; the only test is whether somebody else fills in the same table the same way without seeing mine.

Would you be willing to spend half an hour on it? It is a twelve-by-eight grid: twelve Traditions down the side, eight things a group provides across the top, and you mark which Traditions affect the supply of which things. There are no right answers, I am not testing you, and a disagreement is more useful to me than agreement.

One condition: please fill it in before I tell you anything else about the project. If you already know the argument, the exercise does not work.

Longer version, if they want to know what they are contributing to

The project is a long piece of research about how groups that decide by discussion stay reliable, using AA as its case. One part of it depends on a table I wrote down myself, saying which of the Traditions governs the supply of which of the things a group gives its members.

Everything else in the project has been checked to death: the model is frozen, every number is reproducible from a cache, there are checkers that fail if a figure in the text does not match the data. None of that touches this table, because every check varies the numbers in it and takes its shape as given. One person's judgement is load-bearing and there is no computational way around that.

So I am asking two or three people to fill in the same grid independently. Half an hour. If you and the others leave the same rows empty as I did, that part of the argument gets independent support for the first time. If you do not, one of my chapters is wrong, and I would rather find that out from you than from a reviewer.

The analysis was written before any form came back, so I cannot pick the flattering comparison after the fact.

The one thing I have to ask: fill it in before reading any of the project. If you have already read the relevant part, tell me and I will note it, but the answers will not count as independent.

If they ask what happens to their answers

They are compared with the original on three things: which rows come out empty, how the whole grid agrees cell by cell, and what happens to the conclusions when the analysis is rerun

on their version instead of the original. The form itself says this. Nothing is published under their name, and their name is not recorded in the project: each form is filed under an anonymous code, and the record notes, under that code only, what they were told and whether they had seen the book.